

AM I FORGETTING SOMETHING?

The cold hit me before the panic did. It wasn't just a chill; it was a violent, freezing shock that punched the breath straight from my lungs. My mouth opened in an instinctive, desperate gasp, but instead of oxygen, I swallowed the freezing dark.

I'm not dead yet.

That thought was almost comforting.

Then a sharp pain pierced my abdomen. I tried to scream. Nothing came out. I tried to move my arms, my legs, anything, but my body refused to obey. Every muscle felt numb. Heavy. Distant.

Why can't I move?

I tried opening my eyes.

Nothing.

Why do I feel so weak? Why am I numb?

Then something changed.

A strange sensation spread across my skin. It felt as though something was touching me everywhere at once. My body felt strangely weightless, almost as if I were floating. Yet at the same time, there was an unbearable pressure crushing down on me. Then the pain struck again. Sharper. Deeper. It tore through my abdomen so violently that I thought my body might split apart. I tried to scream. Still nothing

Am I forgetting something?

There was something important. Something I was supposed to remember. I concentrated desperately, searching through the fog in my mind.

And then I felt it. A faint thumping beneath my ribs. My heart. Slow. Too slow.

A sudden realization slammed into my mind.

I wasn't breathing.

Panic exploded through me. I moved every muscle I could, violently, desperately. My eyes snapped open.

What the hell is happening?

I was drowning. When had this happened?

I tried to scream. I tried to thrash. But the water was everywhere, a crushing, heavy blanket wrapping around my limbs. My arms flailed wildly, uncoordinated and weak, searching for a surface I couldn't find. My legs kicked at the empty abyss beneath me.

Which way is up?

The need to breathe swallowed every other thought.

Breathe.

That was all my mind could think.

Breathe.

It wasn't just ordinary breathlessness—it was a vicious, screaming command from a body that was dying. *Breathe. Breathe. Breathe.* My mind was overridden by that single, desperate demand. My throat burned with the agonizing effort of holding it in. My chest tightened, the muscles of my abdomen seizing in sharp, tearing agony as my lungs begged for a release that wasn't there. I choked, swallowing more water, gagging into the void as the heavy liquid forced its way down my windpipe. Tears mixed with the water around me.

How do I get out?

How did I even end up here?

The panic was deafening. I kicked harder, my muscles screaming in protest, tearing themselves apart in a frantic, uncoordinated fight for survival. I reached up, my fingertips stretching through the freezing currents. The surface had to be close. I just needed one breath. Just one. My muscles screamed in protest, threatening to tear themselves apart. But I kept swimming. The surface was close.

So close.

I could almost reach it.

My fingertips rose toward the shimmering water above me.

Almost.

Almost...

But then water filled my mouth and the last of my strength gave out...

It stole the strength from my arms. It turned my legs to lead. The chaotic thrashing slowed, replaced by a terrifying loss of control. I couldn't command my own body anymore.

Slowly, my eyes opened again. I was still drowning. Above me, sunlight filtered through the water, soft and distant, breaking into trembling fragments.

It was beautiful. I had never noticed how beautiful something so ordinary could be. For some reason, that made it worse.

My mind began to fracture. The roaring in my ears morphed into a strange, high-pitched ringing, blending with the slow, muffled *thump... thump...* of my own failing heart. Time stretched out, snapping at the seams. Everything felt chaotic, yet terrifyingly slow.

Am I forgetting something? Faces. Voices. A life I was supposed to remember. I reached for them desperately, but they dissolved into the water before I could hold on. The sheer terror was slipping away, replaced by a heavy, disorienting fog. The violent burning in my chest began to fade into a strange, detached numbness.

I was floating, yet sinking. The pressure of the deep crushed down on me, but I felt utterly weightless.

I stopped fighting.

The shimmering light above me grew dimmer, the golden rays fading into deep, bruising blues, and then into an endless, suffocating black. It was so quiet down here. So devastatingly lonely.

Maybe this was it. Maybe this was how it ended.